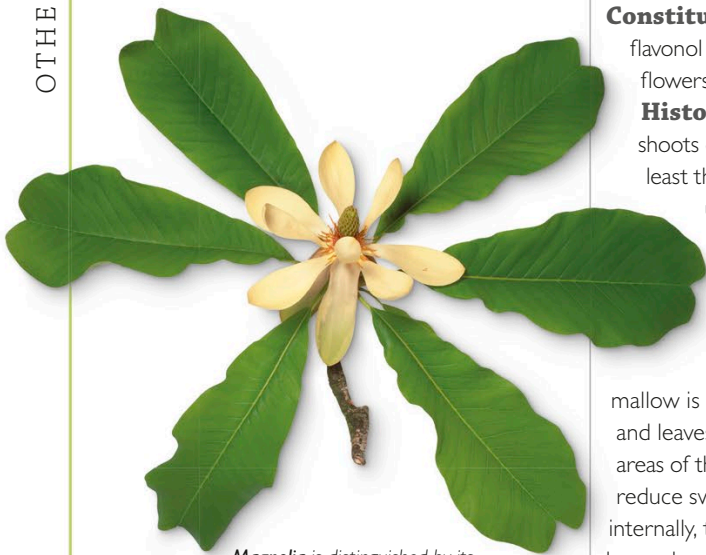


Magnolia officinalis (Magnoliaceae)Magnolia,
Hou Po (Chinese)

Description Deciduous tree growing to 80 ft (25 m). Has aromatic bark, large leaves, and fragrant creamy-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, magnolia grows wild in mountainous regions. It is now planted in many parts of the world as an ornamental tree. The bark is stripped in spring.



Magnolia is distinguished by its beautiful creamy-white flowers.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Magnolia bark contains alkaloids, coumarins, flavonoids, and lignans. The lignan, honokiol, found in the bark of several magnolia species appears to have antitumor and anti-anxiety activity. Another lignan, magnolol, has antibacterial and anti-anxiety activity.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Magnolia bark is aromatic, warming, and pungent. It relieves cramping pain and flatulence, and is taken for abdominal distension, indigestion, loss of appetite, vomiting, and diarrhea. It is now also used to treat anxiety, chronic stress, and lowered mood, and as a neuroprotective remedy that aids memory and mental function.

Research Research suggests that magnolia bark extract is antimicrobial and may have specific use as an oral antiseptic to control bacteria and relieve bad breath (halitosis). Two Italian clinical studies found that magnolia extract helped relieve anxiety and support positive mood in menopausal women. A 2012 Korean study concluded that magnolia may be useful in treating Alzheimer's disease.

Related Species North American species, notably *M. grandiflora*, are used in much the same way as magnolia (above), with traditional uses including for fever and rheumatism.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Malva sylvestris (Malvaceae)

Common Mallow

Description Biennial growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has a pulpy taproot, 5-lobed scalloped leaves, and pink to mauve flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Common mallow is native to Europe and Asia. It is naturalized in the Americas and Australasia, growing in open areas and on hedges and fences. The leaves are gathered in spring, the flowers when in bloom in summer.

Parts Used Leaves, flowers, root.

Constituents Common mallow contains flavonol glycosides, mucilage, and tannins. The flowers also contain malvin (an anthocyanin). **History & Folklore** The young leaves and shoots of this plant have been eaten since at least the 8th century BCE. The plant's many uses gave rise to the Spanish adage, "A kitchen garden and mallow, sufficient medicines for a home."

Medicinal Actions & Uses

Though less useful than marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165), common mallow is an effective demulcent. The flowers and leaves are emollient and good for sensitive areas of the skin. It is applied as a poultice to reduce swelling and draw out toxins. Taken internally, the leaves reduce gut irritation and have a laxative effect. When common mallow is combined with eucalyptus (*Eucalyptus globulus*, p. 96), it makes a good remedy for coughs and other chest ailments. As with marshmallow, the root may be given to children to ease teething.

Mandragora officinarum
(Solanaceae)

Mandrake

Description Perennial growing to 2 in (5 cm). Has a deep branching root, a rosette of broad floppy leaves, funnel-shaped white to purple flowers, and yellow fruit.

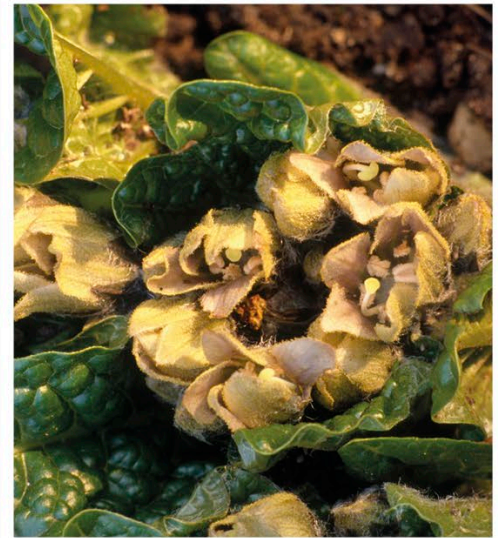
Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Mediterranean region of Europe, mandrake grows on dry riverbeds. Its leaves are picked in summer.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Mandrake contains 0.4% tropane alkaloids (hyoscine and hyoscyamine).

History & Folklore Legend held that the mandrake, on being uprooted, emitted a scream that was so powerful it could kill the person harvesting the plant. Consequently, reported one classical authority, mandrake was pulled up by dogs that had the stems tied to their tails. The fantastic powers attributed to the plant were partly due to the narcotic-like properties of the root. Also

influential was the root's shape, which often vaguely resembles the human form. The roots have been carved and used as talismans for thousands of years, especially to aid fertility in women, and as a charm against misfortune. From Roman times onward, mandrake root bark was used as an anaesthetic and analgesic, and as a treatment for insanity.



Mandrake's narcotic properties and human-shaped root have inspired much legend and lore.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Mandrake has now largely fallen out of use. The herb is sometimes applied as a poultice or plaster for rheumatic and arthritic pains, or, as a decoction, for ulcers and similar kinds of skin disorders.

⚠️ Cautions Mandrake is toxic. Do not take internally. Use externally only under professional supervision. The plant is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Manihot esculenta
(Euphorbiaceae)Cassava,
Manioc

Description Shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has fleshy roots, woody stems, large palm-shaped leaves, and green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Cassava is native to tropical Central and South America. Possibly the most grown root crop in the world, bitter and sweet varieties are grown commercially throughout the tropics (Nigeria, Thailand, and Brazil being the foremost producers). The plant was first cultivated in Peru around 4,000 years ago. The root is unearthed 8 to 24 months after planting.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Cassava contains cyanogenic glycosides (0.02–0.03% in the bitter varieties, 0.007% in the sweet) and starch.